

(application user interface elements). The default is usually -1, meaning Firefox decides the value based on how much RAM you have. Examples are 14336 if you have 256 MB, 22528 if it's 512 MB, and 32768 if you have 1 GB.

A value of 0 here means “do not cache decoded images and chrome in memory.” And if you put in a positive integer here, you're specifying a value manually. Naturally, you'd want to set the value depending on how much RAM you have, and on your browsing habits.



HTTP Pipelining

Normally, Firefox makes one request to a Web page at a time. When you enable something called “pipelining,” it will make several at once, which speeds up page loading. Look at the following three values:

network.http.pipelining

network.http.proxy.pipelining

network.http.pipelining.maxrequests

Set the first and second ones to true.

(It could already be set to true.) As for the third, set it to a number like 20.

This could be considered flooding a server with requests, but then you want speed, right? That's not the final word, though, and some servers might not like it if you set that value too high—it could be considered a Denial of Service (DoS) attack, and you might never be able to load the page. If this seems to be happening, lower the value.



Waiting Before Rendering

The value called **nglayout.initialpaint.delay** may or may not exist on your installation; either navigate to it or create it as an Integer. This value is the amount of time the browser waits before it acts on information it receives. You'd think it should be 0, right? Well, it is 0 in the latest version at the time of writing (1.5.0.4), but it's a positive value in some versions. You might want to set it to 0 in that case.

This is an issue of some debate—some people have reported faster browsing speeds by increasing the value from 0. You'll therefore need to experiment. First try 0, then try something else.



The Download Manager

Here are four things you can do about the download manager dialog. **>>browser.download.manager.showAlertInterval** dictates how long the alert message should be shown. It's in milliseconds, and the default is 2000. You might want to set a lower value. **>>browser.download.manager.openDelay:** by default, the download manager pops up immediately for any download, that is, the value is set to 0. You might not need the download manager at all for small downloads, such as those that take less

than a minute (60000 milliseconds). It's for longer downloads that you might want to have a look at the progress. Adjust accordingly.

>>browser.download.manager.closeWhenDone is set to false by default on some installations, so the manager doesn't close itself. If you set it to true, the thing won't show up when your download is done.

>>browser.download.manager.flashCount flashes the download manager icon in your taskbar for 2 seconds. Adjust that “2” according to your taste.



For Those Low On RAM #1

When Firefox caches your pages to make your browsing fast, it may cause the program to consume memory that needn't be used at all. Drill down to **browser.sessionhistory.max_total_viewers**. The value there is probably -1; set it to 0. The result is *usually* a small decrease in the RAM used, along with a slight decrease in rendering speed, and the action is therefore recommended if you're RAM-challenged.



For Those Low On RAM #2

You can adjust a setting to make Firefox take up less RAM when it is minimised, offloading stuff to the hard disk. Create a new Boolean value called **config.trim_on_minimize**, and set it to True.

Unfortunately, it's not as simple as that: reports indicate that after you minimise Firefox, memory usage does go down, but slowly creeps up as time progresses. You'll have to test this yourself (monitoring memory usage via the Task Manager) and see if it's any good.



For Those Low On RAM #3

Firefox has a special “Back-Forward cache” for recently-visited pages, which works differently from the regular browser cache. The default setting for **browser.sessionhistory.max_total_viewers** is -1. This saves a set number of pages depending on your RAM; some say it saves up to eight pages if you have more than 512 MB of RAM. However, different people

say different things regarding this, but you can try changing the value to 0 for memory savings.



Automatic Updating

Firefox periodically daily checks the Mozilla Update Web site (<http://update.mozilla.org>)—in fact, once a day—to see what's new. If there are critical patches, the home page displayed at startup is replaced with a warning page. If there are any patches at all, an icon appears on the menu bar. To turn off that functionality, make sure **app.update.enabled** is set to False, and set **app.update.autoUpdateEnabled** to False. The latter setting stops Firefox from polling the Web server to see if there's anything new to report to you.

Then, there's the question of updating your Extensions—the same thing applies. The corresponding **about:config** values are **extensions.update.enabled** and **extensions.update.autoUpdateEnabled**. Set both these to False to prevent Firefox from automatically trying to update extensions.



An Appearance/Time Trade-Off

If your Bookmarks toolbar contains a lot of bookmarks that have site icons, Firefox will download them all in order to make the toolbar look pretty. Site icons can also be downloaded if the sidebar is displayed. To turn off icon retrieval, set **browser.chrome.site_icons** and **browser.chrome.favicons** to False.



A Convenience/Data-Pull Trade-Off

You'll often find yourself spending a lot of time looking at one Web page while lots of other pages are loaded into tabs behind the current tab. The most *convenient* arrangement is to have those tabs load their pages while they're still hidden. When you change tabs, it's likely that the page in the tab will be ready to view, and this is the default. At the same time, if you maintain, say, five tabs, you're demanding five times more data. In this age of tabbed browsing, people often open tabs “just in case.” So it *could* be a waste to load the background tabs.

So drill down to **browser.tabs.loadInBackground** and set it to False if you seem to exhibit the above behaviour, that is, keeping tabs open “just in case.”



Disable IPv6

On some Linux distributions, Firefox has issues with Google servers because of difficulties with the IPv6 protocol. You can try changing **network.dns.disableIPv6** to True.



Dancing Ads

Don't you *hate* animated GIF ads—assuming you haven't installed Adblock—dancing away while you're trying to read?

Bet You Didn't Know

Googling Made Easy

In Firefox, typing keywords in the main address bar by default searches Google for those keywords! You don't need to use the Google toolbar! The catch is that the default setting is to use the “I'm feeling lucky” option. Browse down to the String keyword.URL. Try setting it to “<http://www.google.com/search?q=>”, which is the Google search string for general searches, without the quotes. Now when you enter a word in the address bar and press [Enter], it will take you to the Google results page.